

Nothing Ear (a)

Feature-rich in-ear earphone for the audiophile on a budget

Nothing, after the launch of the Nothing Ear 1, solidified their position in the mid-range TWS segment in India. With their latest TWS in-ear earphones, they announced a new naming scheme, with their flagship in-ear earphones now being called Nothing Ear (2024) and their lower tier offering, called the Nothing Ear (a).

Let's dive into the full review of the Nothing Ear (a), and find out whether these in-ear earphones warrant a hefty Rs 7,999 price tag or are there better deals out there for you to consider –

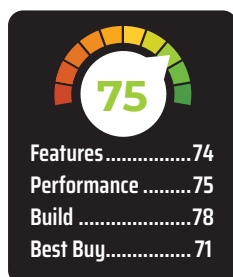


BUILD AND DESIGN

Nothing stayed true to their brand philosophy of making stellar-looking products with their signature transparent design with the Nothing Ear (a). The major distinguishing factor in the design of these buds is the splash of colour. Let's start by looking at the case of the buds.

It is a sleek, lightweight case, with great pocketability. You see a lip around the seam of the case, which is not my favourite because it got stuck on my pocket seam whenever I was pulling these in-ear earphones in and out of it. But others at the Digit Test Centre did not mind it as much. The case has a nice heft, which gives it a premium feel in the hands. The magnets holding the buds in place and the lid closed are fairly strong. There is not much to complain about. You can open the case with one hand, and the hinge, which is metal (love that), is snappy and holds its own. And, not to forget, my personal favourite, the pairing button.

The Nothing Ear (a) is a pair of TWS in-ear earphones that will not leave much to complain about the fit, for many people who buy it. The fundamental design of the buds remains the same as that of the



Nothing Ear (1) and the Ear (2). Before moving ahead, the regular reminder for anyone reading the review - Everything in the world of audio products is very subjective, including the fit of the in-ear earphones. So, I would recommend you try out the buds for yourself before going forward with your purchase.

However, while the colour scheme and design, for the most part, may be palatable for the folks willing to experiment with the looks of the buds, many might find it a bit too overwhelming. Thanks to the scratch-prone body of the case and the buds, and they seem to fall off a lot of people's lists, who might have been drawn to the product because of its design.

FEATURES

Nothing has loaded these in-ear earphones with features. First off, ChatGPT support. The ChatGPT integration, to my annoyance, works only with Nothing Phones. It definitely is responsive and works well, and for the fans of AI-powered assistants and generative models, it is a great addition to the product. However, Nothing, in my opinion, should have baked it into the Nothing X app itself to

make it more accessible to people outside of the upcoming "Nothing Ecosystem". They might not label it, but it is coming.

Moving to Microsoft Swift Pair and Google Fast Pair. Coupled with the dual device connectivity option that this device offers, makes it a seamless experience. Most brands these days offer only Google Fast Pair, and the inclusion of Microsoft Swift Pair makes life easy for the folks using a Windows PC, and Android phone. For the folks who are tied into the Apple Ecosystem, like me, it is a slightly long-drawn process to pair and manage the connectivity between the two devices. This is when you will start to love the pairing button.

Nothing Ear (a) comes with support for the Nothing X app, which adds a bunch of necessary features to the device. The design of the app is awesome, and we have written loads about the same. Let's move to the features that are packed into the Nothing X app.

First off is the customisable EQ. You get two modes when you are working with the EQ – simple and advanced. Having two different modes makes this customisation layer more accessible to everyone, and I love it. The simple EQ has three bands for you to work around. When you switch to the Advanced mode, you get 8 bands to play with and tons of other options, which make it an audiophile's dream.

In addition to the customisable EQ, you can also customise the ANC (with a 4-step customisation option) and transparency mode. Everything from controls to the Bass Enhance feature is definitely something that makes your experience much better overall. Additions like low-latency mode for gamers and clear voice technology, which is supposed to make your calls sound better, all add to the overall user experience. Home run scored in this department.

Lastly, in this long list of features, I would like to talk about the Hi-Res CODEC support offered by these in-ear earphones. While I would hold off on giving my word about the sound signature of these buds right now, the addition of these CODECs, which includes LDAC, ensures that people streaming high-quality music get the most out of these in-ear earphones. We have seen some